

not too hot, but ensure that trees have not become pot-bound. Bare-root trees should be planted between late fall and early spring, unless the soil is frozen.

Dig in plenty of well-rotted manure or compost before planting, since plums, damsons, and gages all prefer a fertile soil. Water in well, and apply an organic mulch around the base. Young trees need staking for their first few years of growth.

CROP CARE

Keep trees well-watered to help prevent fruits from splitting (see box, right). Feed trees with a balanced fertilizer in late winter and a nitrogenous fertilizer in early spring. Mulch around the base of trunks with well-rotted



Thin out fruits to encourage strong growth.

manure, compost, or bark chippings after feeding.

Plums, damsons, and gages flower relatively early in the season, and may need protection with fleece if frosts occur—this may not be feasible for larger trees, but will be much easier for container-grown or wall-trained types. Plums, damsons, and

TIP PRUNING

Whether you are training your tree or simply pruning it, only do so between late spring and early fall to reduce the risk of infection from silver leaf or bacterial canker. Use sterilized tools, and prune out diseased wood first to promote an open, well-ventilated branch structure. Plums fruit on two- or three-year-old wood, so the aim of pruning is to clean up the tree rather than remove too much of the old wood.



Like other stone fruit, prune plums in summer while leaves are still out.